Reading on Screens

1. Section 1

The question of how people actually read on screens has been studied for decades, and the findings are less intuitive than designers usually assume. Reading is not a smooth sweep across a line of text but a sequence of saccades and fixations, and the eye lands on only about seventy percent of the words on a page.

Typographic interventions therefore tend to work indirectly. Widening the space between lines does not make individual words easier to recognise; it makes the return sweep to the start of the next line more reliable, which is a different mechanism entirely. A reader who loses their line is a reader who re-reads.

Hyphenation is the clearest illustration of the trade-off. Justified text without hyphen-ation opens rivers of whitespace that pull the eye downward, and long words compound the problem. The remedy is unglamorous: allow hyphens, or set the text flush left and accept a ragged right edge.

Three consequences follow:

- Line length interacts with line height.
- Font size is not the same lever as font weight.
- Colour contrast has a floor but no useful ceiling.

2. Section 2

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